WHITE PAPER · PORTFOLIO AND AI GOVERNANCE

The people your AI review says gained nothing are teaching the tool

When a tool learns from your best staff, judging its benefit person by person undervalues the source



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THE CENTRAL ARGUMENT

A year into an AI program, weaker staff have sped up and top performers show no gain. Suppose the tool learns mostly from your top performers' work and keeps learning. Then part of that gain is theirs, passed on through the tool, and the tool may be nudging their quality down. Moving people by measured gain can wear down that source. Before renewing, ask whose work the tool learns from. Judge those people on quality rather than speed, and protect what they give the tool.

Your AI program has run for a year, and the funding review is coming. You have the figures you asked for. Weaker and newer staff are much faster with the tool. Your best people show little or no gain, and their quality has slipped a little. The natural next step is to follow the gain. That means hiring fewer seasoned people, leaving some departures unfilled and moving the people with no measured gain to other work.

If the tool learns mostly from your best people's work, that reading can be upside down. Part of the weaker staff's gain is your best people's work, passed on through the tool. The people who show no gain are the ones the tool learns from most. And the tool itself may have nudged their quality down. A review that judges each person by their own gain sees no value in that source. The moves it suggests can wear that source down.

So begin the review with two questions for the AI team or the vendor. Does this tool learn from our own staff's work, and mostly from whose? Does it keep learning from current work? If it never learns from your staff's work, or learns evenly from everyone's, this paper does not apply. If it learns mostly from your best people and keeps learning, the renewal should do three things. It should record their work as an input to everyone else's gain. It should judge them on quality rather than speed. And it should protect what they give the tool.

ARGUMENT AT A GLANCE

Where the gain lands, and where it starts

Where it lands

Weaker staff: 36 percent more issues resolved per hour in one study.

Where it starts

Top performers' work, given extra weight in the tool's training.

What to protect

Their quality and the new examples they keep supplying.

Applies where the tool learns mostly from top performers' work and keeps learning from current work.

Where the gain shows

Most sponsors know the basics of judging an AI program. Use is not value, and benefits are measured against a baseline. Many also know these tools tend to help weaker and newer staff most. A large field study bears this out. Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li and Lindsey Raymond studied a customer-support operation that gave its agents an AI assistant [1]. It is one tool in one firm and one kind of job. The authors warn against applying it to all jobs and all AI systems. The least skilled fifth of agents resolved 36 percent more customer issues per hour. The top performers showed no significant change in issues resolved per hour.

In that study, skill means how well an agent performed before the tool arrived, not how long they had been there. Top performers and long-serving staff overlap, but they are not the same people.

Where the gain comes from

A review naturally concludes that the gain lives with the weaker staff. The study points further back. The tool was trained on the firm's own support conversations. The vendor gave extra weight to conversations handled by top performers. And those agents' conversations kept feeding the tool's training [1]. The authors say the pattern of gains is consistent with the tool passing top performers' practices on to everyone else. The weaker agents learned something new, while "the best performers may see little benefit from being exposed to their own best practices." The authors conclude that a worker's productivity "also includes the AI training data they produce."

That is the authors' reading of the pattern. They do not split the gain by where it came from. The underlying model, the vendor's training on tone and the tool's links to the firm's documents all helped too. But that reading is enough to change what your figures mean. The gain is recorded against the person using the tool. Part of its source is the people whose work trained the tool, and those people gain least. A person-by-person reading puts the whole gain where it lands and none where it starts. For a top performer, no gain does not mean no value.

This holds only where the tool learns mostly from top performers. A tool trained evenly on everyone's work does not make the link. Neither does a vendor model that never learns from your company's work. That is why the review starts by asking how your tool was trained.

How the source wears down

The usual moves after a review like this are based on seniority, cost or measured gain: fewer seasoned hires, departures left unfilled, people moved to other work. They do not have to aim at top performers to reach them. Each one can leave fewer of the people whose work the tool learns from.

The tool works on its source as well. In the same study, top performers' resolution rates and customer satisfaction dropped slightly but measurably once they had the tool [1]. The authors suggest one possible reason. The tool may lead top performers to take the faster, easier option rather than work out their own answer. They add that this matters "because the conversations of top agents are used for ongoing AI training."

The study did not see what happens when top performers leave. So the next step is a judgment, not a finding. Suppose the tool keeps learning from current work. Then fewer top performers, or top performers leaning on the tool, mean fewer strong new examples. Over time that gives a tool that teaches older practice.

A fair objection is that the tool already holds years of good examples, and those do not leave with the people. Where the work is stable, as it was in the study, that is largely true, and the risk builds slowly. Where products or customers change quickly, the authors note two possibilities. The tool may be better at picking up changing best practices. Or it could hold back learning "by promoting outdated practices observed in historical training data" [1]. Neither is a result. Which one happens depends on whether the tool keeps getting good new examples. Those new examples are what the usual moves put at risk. So the cost does not show in the first year's figures. It builds as the work changes and the examples age, and it falls hardest where the work changes most.

What the renewal should do

Suppose part of the gain starts with your top performers. Suppose too that the usual moves and the tool itself can wear that source down. Then, where the work changes, the renewal has to count those people and protect them. Otherwise it funds the gain while running down its source.

Ask the AI team or the vendor whose work the tool learns from and whether it keeps learning. Have the review record the answers. Keep those people on that work. Judge them on quality, such as resolution rates and customer satisfaction, rather than speed, and track those figures in the review. Give them time to review the tool's suggestions and supply better ones. The authors say rewards for contributing to the tool's training "could be important." They also report one manager's account that high-skill agents in some contact centers already review the tool's suggestions and provide better alternatives [1]. That is a report, not a measured result. The steps here are a judgment built on the study, not its findings.

The weaker staff's gains still count. Hours saved is a fair measure when it serves the business. It stops counting as a gain if a quality measure, agreed in advance, falls.

There are cheaper steps, and one of them may be the place to start. Turning the suggestions off for top performers may protect their quality. They keep writing their own answers. Where their conversations still feed the tool's training, those are the fresh examples the tool needs. What that leaves out is anyone correcting the tool's weak suggestions for everyone else. Having the vendor pick out past strong examples is cheaper still. But it keeps the old practice and adds nothing new, so it helps only where the work is stable.

The time top performers spend improving the tool is time not spent with customers. The business pays that cost every year. It is worth paying where the tool learns mostly from them, keeps learning from current work, and the work keeps changing. Where the work is stable, it can wait.

At the renewal, ask where the gain lands and where it starts. A review that answers only the first can fund the gain and lose its source.

Sources

1. Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li and Lindsey Raymond, The Quarterly Journal of Economics. Generative AI at Work (2025).